



Ethiopian
Community
Los Angeles

2025 Annual Report

January - August, 2025



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Who We Are

Vision

Our vision is to see Ethiopian immigrants in Los Angeles and its surroundings be fully integrated, united, equally addressed, and benefitted from the socio-economic and educational opportunities available in the country while advancing their culture, history and heritage.

Mission

Ethiopian Community Los Angeles is committed to supporting Ethiopian immigrants, refugees, and individuals in comparable circumstances, by promoting social integration, economic and educational development, and by preserving cultural heritage.

Our Values

- **Inclusiveness:** We foster an environment where members feel safe, respected, and comfortable expressing all aspects of their identities.
- **Diversity & Autonomy:** We celebrate the unique diversity of our members and honor their individual autonomy.
- **Responsible Service:** We empower members to serve with transparency, accountability, and responsibility.
- **Stewardship:** We practice responsible stewardship of resources, ensuring expenditures align with our mission.
- **Intergenerational Connection:** We intentionally encourage intergenerational interactions to promote the transfer of language, culture, and history.
- **Community Access:** We connect our communities to social and government programs quickly, effectively, and equitably.
- **Transparency:** We commit to publicly sharing financial records, highlighting results, and openly displaying our impact through data.
- **Accountability & Trust:** We build trust by upholding accountability to one another, our mission, our members, donors, partners, and the broader public.



Meet Our Team

BOARD OF DIRECTORS

HIROUT DAGNEW

EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR 2020-PRESENT

DENKINESH ARGAW

INTERIM BOARD SECRETARY 2024-2025

MEKONNEN GAREDEW

BOARD MEMBER 2024-2025

LIBONA KEBEDE

INTERIM BOARD MEMBER 2024-2025

DAVID MESFIN

INTERIM BOARD MEMBER 2024-2025

MESSERET YILMA

BOARD CHAIR 2024-2026

SINE YOHANNES

INTERIM BOARD TREASURER 2024-2025

JHAILA BROWN

BOARD MEMBER 2024-2026

MAHELET GEZACHEW

BOARD MEMBER 2024-2026

ADVISORY BOARD

FASSIL ABEBE

2024-2026

HANNIBAL KASSAYE

2024-2026

GETACHEW TAMRAT

2024-2025

SAMUEL WOLDEYOHANES

2024-2026

STAFF

IMRAN BELETE AHMED

MEMBERSHIP COORDINATOR

RABIA DAHAL

BOOKKEEPER

REBECCA BEYENE

DIGITAL MEDIA COORDINATOR

TERECHE GELAYE

AMHARIC INSTRUCTOR

Volunteer Spotlight

ABSERA ASSEFA

BEZUAYEHU G/KIDAN

DEBRA WORKENEH

ELSABET MESFIN

ESKEDAR GIZAW

FISSEHA ASMEROM

HAILU SOLOMON

ISABEL SHAWEL

KIRUBEL F/SELASSIE

LETARIK TADESSE

MARTHA NEGASH

MEGDELLA GERMACHEW

RAHEL WOUBESHET

SAMMY BEYENE

SEWSEW FANTAYE

TABI HIWOT

TERECHE MENGISTU

TIZEBT ALEMAYEHU

WORKU SHIBESHI

BETHLEHEM SHIFFERAW

BLAYNESH BEZABIH

ELIAS NEGASH

ELSIE MITIKU

FIKRE WOLDESELASSIE

GUENET YOHANNES

HAYFA DAWOOD

KEDEST ALEMAYEHU

LELINA BERU

LYDIA SHIFERRAW

MARTHA TADESSE

RABIA DAHAL

ROMMANE KEBEDE

SELAM YEHDEGO

SHIFERAW DENEKE

TEDJITOU DESSALEGN

TESFAYE ZELEKE

TSEGA WORKU

YEWIENESHET ZEWDE

Executive Summary

At ECLA, everything we do comes from a place of service, resilience, and empowerment. We started because we saw, up close, the challenges Ethiopian immigrants and refugees face when they arrive in the U.S. with big hopes but run into barriers with school, work, and access to resources.

For us, this isn't just work. It's our mission. We know what it feels like to be overlooked or to have talent and wisdom go unseen. And we also know how powerful it can be when people get the right support at the right time. Our community is full of strength, multilingual skills, and intergenerational wisdom—sometimes it just needs a bridge to opportunity.

That's why our programs cover so much ground: mental health support, immigration services, youth development, older adult advocacy, workforce pathways, and leadership building. We're not only helping people find jobs; we're helping restore dignity, build confidence, and open doors to independence and civic life.

This year, we have so much to celebrate. On February 3, 2025, we purchased our very first property in South Los Angeles with the EDI grant we received through our fiscal sponsor, the African Communities Public Health Coalition. Opening an ECLA Center has been a long-time dream for our community, and now it's finally becoming reality. We took important steps this year to strengthen our infrastructure by expanding our team. Two talented part-time staff members joined our efforts: a digital media coordinator and a membership coordinator. These additions have allowed us to enhance our outreach, build stronger relationships within our community, and provide more comprehensive support to those we serve. By investing in our team, we are investing in the long-term sustainability and impact of our mission. Over the next two years, our goal is to build up to full staffing so we can expand our impact even more.

ECLA has always been about community lifting community. We're here because of our collective effort, and that spirit continues in everything we do. The challenges are real, but so is the strength of our people. That's why we show up every day—and why this work matters so deeply to us.

Hirout Dagnew
Executive Director





Building Community With Our Elders

Over the past two years, our Older Adults services has become a real gathering place for connection, support, and joy. What started with simple translation help and a few forms has now grown into a full circle of services that touch nearly every part of our older adults' lives.

Every week, older adults came by for one-on-one help—whether it was to fill out Medicare, housing applications, understanding paperwork, or just having someone who could translate and explain things clearly. For many, this meant finally getting benefits they were eligible for or being able to make a doctor's appointment without stress. Our bilingual team became a trusted bridge, and word spread quickly in the community.

Transportation can be a big barrier, so we helped many apply for transportation vouchers—a small thing that made a huge difference in helping older adults get to appointments, markets, and social gatherings. We also organized intergenerational picnics which reduced isolation and reminded our elders that they are part of something bigger than themselves.

Thanks to local partners, we offered free legal consultations and healthcare info sessions. These moments were powerful: people left not just with answers, but with confidence that they had rights and options.

The heart of it all has been the relationships built. We've seen neighbors become friends, shy participants turn into active voices, and elders who once stayed home alone now show up every week with stories to share.

In just two years, we've helped hundreds of older adults feel seen, supported, and connected. The program has become a lifeline—whether that's through a bus pass, a translated form, or a shared laugh at a workshop.

We're proud of how far we've come, and we're even more excited for what's ahead. With continued support, we'll keep growing this circle of care so that no elders in our community ever feel left behind.



Immigration Services

ECLA empowers Ethiopian immigrants and underserved communities in the Greater Los Angeles area by offering comprehensive immigration support and culturally sensitive programs that simplify the immigration process through accessible guidance and advocacy. By bridging resources and creating inclusive pathways to stability, we ensure that individuals can thrive socially, emotionally, and economically in a supportive environment.

In the current immigration environment, we are living through many policy upheavals that are greatly impacting our immigrant community. We work closely with other immigrant nonprofit allies, legal aid partners, and we make use of our trusted in-house pro bono, bilingual, immigration attorneys. We are filled with gratitude for all the support.

We are accessible to the immigrants seeking help through our ECLA number and if they are over fifty years old, we conduct a weekly One Stop at a local Senior Center to break down language barriers. Until we move into our offices we conduct in person meet ups at local libraries, and host Zoom clinics. Each client's immigration needs are unique and through our network of nonprofits we offer guidance on eligibility, next steps, and documentation. We have access to a volunteer paralegal that assists with the preparation and submission of a range of immigration forms such as family-based petitions and asylum documentation. We host multicultural workshops that educate community members about their rights, available protections, with special attention to non-English speaking underserved groups. We also make multilingual webinars our allies share with us accessible to our community.

We remain a consistent source of support, helping clients track deadlines, respond to notices, and access social services during their legal journey. We advocate for humane immigration policies and connect immigrants with opportunities to share their stories and shape public discourse.

We are grateful for the African Communities Public Health Coalition, Black Migrants for Immigration Justice, and the African Communities Together for being our allies and helping us uplift our communities. We are especially indebted to our in-house attorneys Aiemero Lulseged and Rhoda Sherif for their impactful work that is changing immigrant lives. We are most appreciative of being part of this network of nonprofits.



Mental Health Support for the Community

ECLA is dedicated to empowering Ethiopian immigrants and underserved communities in Greater Los Angeles by providing mental health services that honor the cultural backgrounds of those served. Our approach centers on accessibility, inclusivity, and community-driven care, ensuring that mental wellness resources reach individuals and families in ways that are meaningful and effective for them.

We recognize that true support means meeting people where they are—whether geographically, culturally, or emotionally. By partnering with local clinics, schools, and community centers, we integrate mental health support into the daily lives of our neighborhoods. This strategy not only expands access but also fosters trust and engagement within the community.

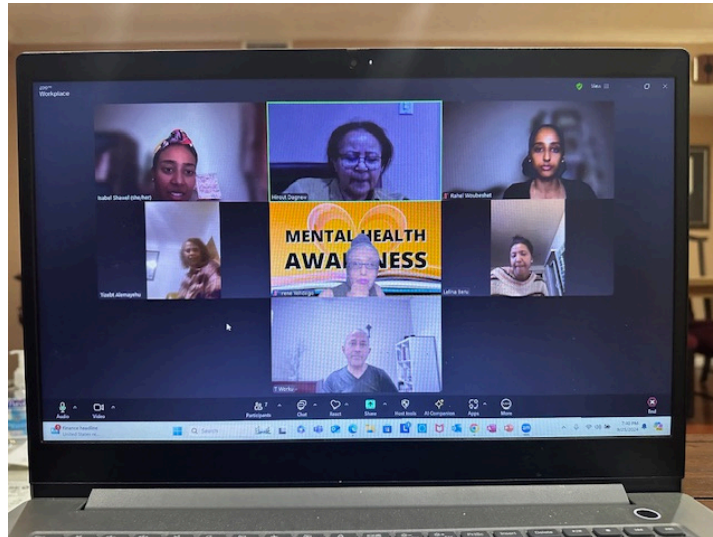
Our commitment to culturally competent care is reflected in the makeup of our team, which mirrors the diverse communities we serve. ECLA professionals are trained in cultural sensitivity and collaborate with local leaders to eliminate language and cultural barriers, making mental health services more approachable and relevant.

This past year, the launch of our bilingual mental health support groups marked a significant milestone. Clinicians ensured that resources were available in both English and Amharic, with translated handouts so that no participant was excluded from the conversation. Despite facing budgetary challenges that impacted some partnerships, such as the Los Angeles County Promoters workshops, ECLA's commitment to culturally sensitive outreach remained steadfast. Our team is always ready to support families in crisis, including homeless shelter visits, when the need arises.

One of the year's highlights was the Mental Wellbeing Summit, “A Drop of Hope,” which welcomed 124 community members. This event fostered healing, connection, and a shared understanding, particularly for families navigating autism. The summit provided resources, peer support, and a sense of belonging to guests, siblings, and parents, who often find themselves isolated.

Through these ongoing efforts, ECLA demonstrates the profound impact that arises when culture, language, and compassion intersect. The organization continues to create environments where every individual feels recognized, supported, and empowered on their journey to mental wellness.

Mental Health Team



New Initiatives in Planning: Workforce Development

ECLA plans to pilot a small-scale workforce development initiative this coming year. We are currently building partnerships with employers in the Aviation and Health fields. We plan to enroll recent arrivals from our community and members of other immigrant communities to implement a 12-month workforce development initiative. Forging partnerships with employers and community colleges will help us cut costs down.

Our training will offer language support, job readiness training, and community engagement. Here at ECLA we struggle to meet the needs of the newly arrived immigrants who because of financial considerations end up being stuck in jobs that do not pay well and lack a career track. Our biggest challenge will be keeping up with the translation of both digital and printed content for use in workshops, and materials for outreach. We have no shortage of skilled volunteers. We plan to start by hosting mostly monthly bilingual job readiness workshops and connecting participants with local employers and workforce agencies.



ECLA's New Community Center



We are working on launching a fully equipped Ethiopian community hub in Los Angeles as soon as we are done with the building renovations. Our biggest task will be to strengthen identity, access, and belonging for immigrants and refugees. To support the sustainability of our new office and expanded programming, ECLA is implementing a series of mission-aligned revenue streams. We plan to have revenue- generating services like ESL, tutoring, coffee corner, legal services, job readiness workshops, meeting room rentals, and ticketed cultural events.

We have a staffing growth plan that will eventually lead to full team model within two years. We aim to have our services reach diverse age groups, offering support to new arrivals and long-standing residents alike. Our strategic priorities include expanding workforce development programs, deepening partnerships with clinics, schools, and cultural institutions. Operating support will be a critical foundation for these goals- enabling us to grow impact without sacrificing integrity or accessibility.

ECLA maintains a \$50,000 annual operating budget, funded through a mix of grants, individual donations, membership dues, and added in-kind support. Operating support is crucial at this time since it would enhance stability, help grow a reserve fund, and diversify our funding streams through planned grant expansion and community fundraising. Operating support will allow ECLA to stabilize part-time staff, maintain our physical and digital infrastructure, continue delivering high-impact services year-round, and conduct strategic planning for sustainable growth.

Investing in staff positions will directly improve program efficiency, increase service delivery consistency, and expand ECLA's ability to raise funds. The initial roles will be instrumental in supporting ECLA's cultural, educational, health, and immigration programming, while also laying the groundwork for sustainable nonprofit growth. This will help bridge the transition from a volunteer-driven model to a professionalized community institution.

Volunteers are essential to ECLA's mission. To scale our impact and sustain our growing programs, we are implementing a structured volunteer strategy focused on recruitment, management, and documentation of hours.

This strategic launch combines physical infrastructure, staff growth, and earned revenue to ensure that ECLA continues to uplift the Ethiopian community through inclusive, responsive, and culturally relevant services. The model is scalable, community-rooted, and funder-aligned.

ECLA Spotlight



BLAYNESH BEZABIH

ECLA'S FIRST PUBLIC HEALTH INTERN

Blaynesh Bezabih, known to many as Abby, joined ECLA as the very first public health intern while studying Public Health at California State University, Northridge, CSUN). For her, the internship was more than just a learning opportunity, it was a chance to connect deeply with the Ethiopian community and contribute to projects that directly support community well-being.

One of her most memorable experiences was creating and conducting an ECLA health survey and assessment. "It was incredibly rewarding to speak face-to-face with community members, listen to their concerns, and gain a better understanding of their health needs," she shared. "I was able to put what I've learned in the classroom into practice, which made me feel proud to use my education to give back to my community."

Blaynesh also helped translate important health education materials into Amharic, breaking down language barriers and making vital information more accessible. Through this work, she discovered how essential language and communication are in helping people connect with resources and services.

Reflecting on her time with ECLA, she says the experience taught her the importance of cultural understanding, empathy, and respect in public health work. "Being present, listening closely, and approaching each person with care makes all the difference, especially when serving communities with unique challenges."

She expressed deep gratitude to her field supervisor, Martha Tadesse, MSN, MPH, for her mentorship and support throughout the internship, and to ECLA for creating the opportunity. "I'm truly thankful to ECLA for entrusting me with this role. I grew both professionally and personally, and I'm inspired to continue pursuing community-centered impactful public health work." Blaynesh is currently running for one of the vacant seats on the ECLA Board.



SEWASEW FANTAYE

ECLA VOLUNTEER & HEALTH ADVOCATE

Sewasew Fantaye is an oncology nurse navigator and volunteers at ECLA to advocate for our cancer patients. An oncology nurse navigator serves as a patient advocate and care coordinator within the community, helping individuals diagnosed with cancer access timely, personalized care. Cancer navigators provide education, emotional support, and assistance with overcoming barriers such as transportation, language

differences, and more. By connecting patients with appropriate community resources and support services, oncology nurse navigators improve care continuity, reduce disparities, and empower patients to actively participate in their treatment journey. We are thrilled she joined our team this year.

ECLA's Rebranding Project

Board member David Mesfin is leading ECLA's rebranding initiative in collaboration with a professional web designer. This project aims to develop a cohesive and compelling brand identity that inspires trust and confidence from donors, grant-makers, and the broader community.

The rebranding effort will align our volunteers, staff, board members, and community around a shared vision. Once completed, ECLA's external image will more accurately reflect our current mission, values, and strategic goals. We envision this new identity strengthening our connection with the immigrant community and resonating with younger and underserved audiences.

A refreshed brand will increase ECLA's visibility both online and in the community, enabling us to better articulate our impact, value, and uniqueness. Most importantly, it will energize our team and open new opportunities for meaningful engagement with stakeholders, creating a sense of unity and momentum for the future.



2025 Highlights

Number of older adults engaged this year:	280
Applications supported (Medicare, housing, benefits):	100
Workshops hosted:	6
Adult Mental health support groups hosted:	12
Young Adult Peer Support Spaces:	12
Transportation vouchers distributed:	20
Free legal consultations provided:	40
Community outings and events organized:	7

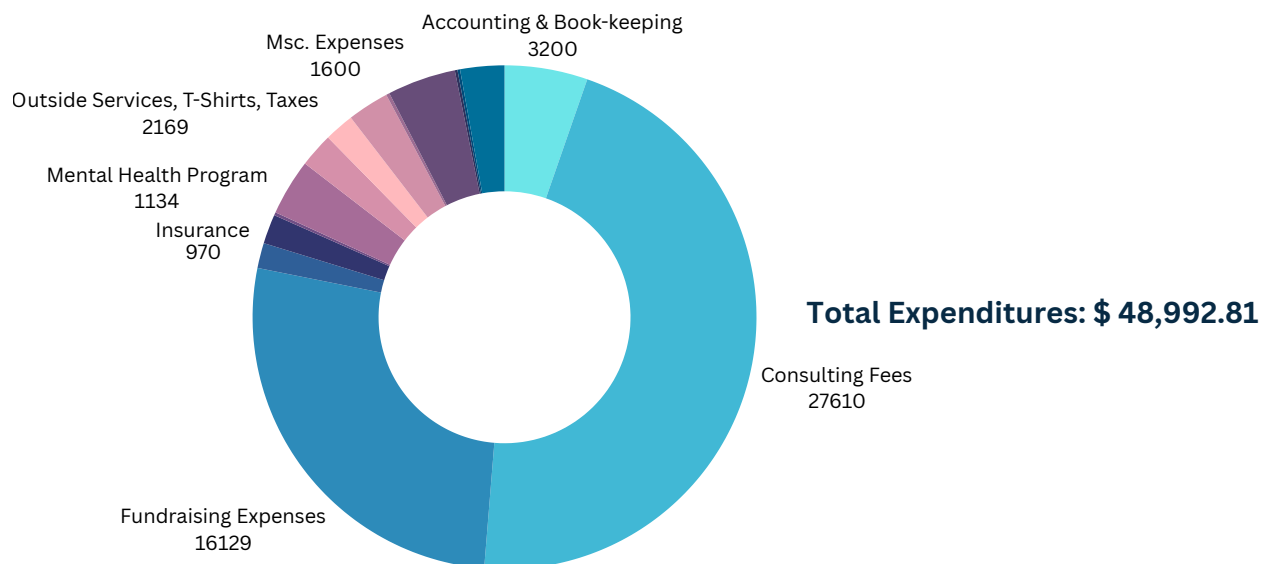


Analytics

Profits & Loss

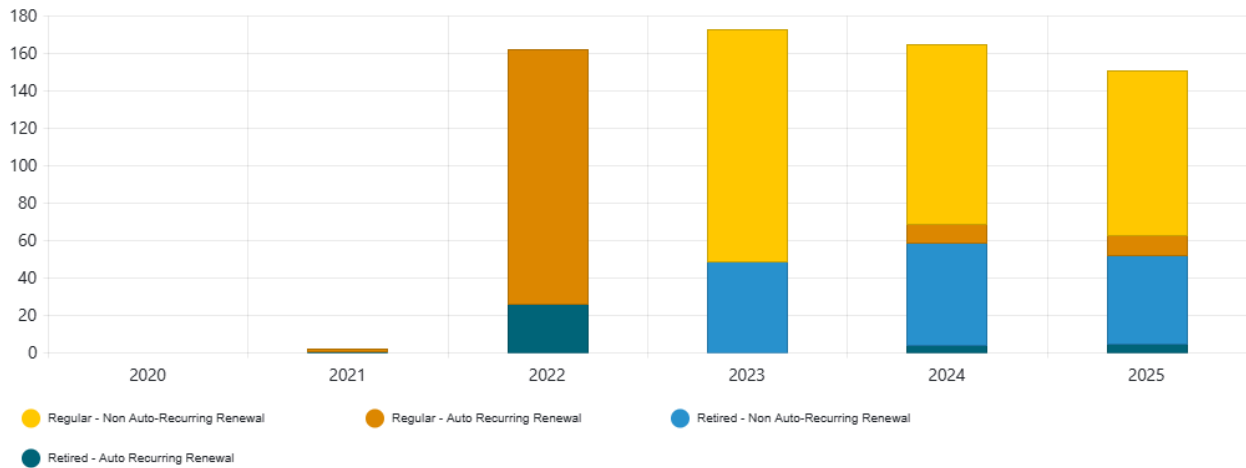
	2025
Total Revenue	\$ 654,543.76
Total Expenditures	\$ 48,992.81
Net Revenue	\$ 605,550.95

Expenditures Breakdown

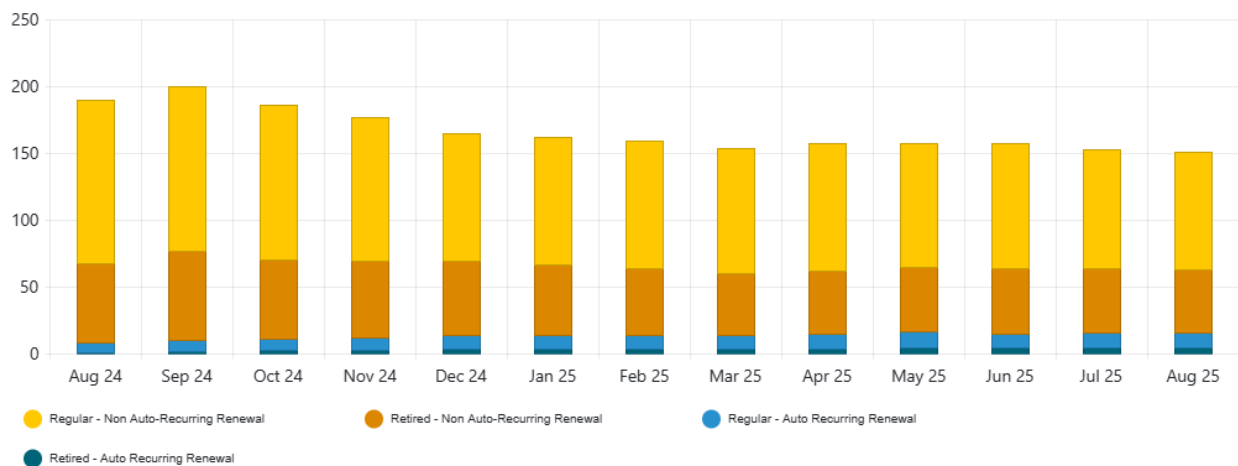


Analytics

Annual Membership Growth



Monthly Membership Growth



Financial Report

Profits & Loss

January - August, 2025

REVENUE	TOTAL
General Donation	773.51
Board Pledge	5,397.25
Donations directed by individuals	8,155.00
Government grants & contracts	630,201.00
Grants from others	5,000.00
In-kind donations	970.00
Total Donation & Grants	650,496.76
Membership Fee	3,460.00
Event Fund Raising Revenue	587.00
Total Revenue	654,543.76
EXPENDITURES	
Accounting & Book-keeping Services	3,200.00
Bank fees & service charges	180.61
Consulting Fee	27,234.56
Consulting fees	375.00
Facilities Rent	1,321.00
Insurance	4,870.85
Mental Health Program	970.00
Misc Expenses	1,133.89
Office expenses	1,600.00
Office supplies	116.97
Outside services	2,169.00
Property Taxes	1,148.50
Shipping & postage	131.16
Software & apps	2,640.01
Supplies	101.56
Taxes, License, and Fees	100.00
Utilities	1,699.70
Total Expenditure	48,992.81
Net Income	605,550.95

Balance Sheet

As of August 31, 2025

ASSETS	TOTAL
<u>Current Assets</u>	
Cash	44,923.77
Prepays and Deposits	659.80
Total Bank Accounts	45,583.57
 <u>Fixed Assets</u>	
Building	421,172.85
Land	180,502.65
Improvements	3,098.40
Furniture & fixtures	225.00
Total Fixed Assets	604,998.90
 Other Assets	
Security deposits	1,400
Total Other Assets	1,400
TOTAL ASSETS	651,982.47
 LIABILITIES AND EQUITY	
<u>Liabilities</u>	
Current Liabilities	180.00
Deferred Revenue	180.00
Total Current Liabilities	180.00
 <u>Equity</u>	
Unrestricted - undesignated	44,343.77
Unrestricted - designated for immigrant funding	400.00
Unrestricted - designated for other expenditure	2,059.80
Unrestricted - designated for capital assets	604,998.90
 Total Equity	651,802.47
TOTAL LIABILITIES AND EQUITY	\$651,982.47

2025 Grant Acknowledgment



First Citizens Bank

With gratitude, ECLA wishes to acknowledge the donation of a full set of office desks and chairs for our new office space by First Citizens Bank.



First
Citizens
Bank
forever first®

2025 Company Matches



Google - Benevity



Edison - American Charities

A huge thank you to all our ardent supporters, members, donors, and incredible volunteers!

Our partners

AFRICAN COMMUNITIES PUBLIC HEALTH COALITION
BLACK ALLIANCE FOR JUST IMMIGRATION
AFRICAN COMMUNITIES TOGETHER
LOS ANGELES COUNTY CBO CALFRESH DPSS
LOS ANGELES COUNTY METRO CBO DPSS
NATIONAL PARKS & RECREATION
COUNTY MENTAL HEALTH
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ST. GABRIEL MEHABER
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